situation had stabilized and that I was cautiously optimistic of an early resolution. Famous last words!

Flag-level meetings had been continuing at other locations, including at PP-15 and PP-17A, where troops fell back over agreed distances, thereby reducing the chances of violent face-offs, and this had been the basis for my prognosis. At PP-14, however, whenever we asked the PLA to remove their tents, they kept changing their stance. From 'some more time was needed', to 'we will check with our superiors', to it 'being beyond the mandate of the talks'. From this stonewalling, it became evident that there had been no intention of removing those tents in the first place. To counter this, we also decided to pitch our own tents in the same general area.

When our party went to pitch the tents, there was a violent reaction from their side. Col Santosh Babu, CO 16 BIHAR, went forward with a small party of troops to attempt to defuse the situation but the PLA were in no mood to relent and attacked the CO's party too. Thereafter, it became a free-for-all. With darkness setting in, both sides rushed in additional troops and a see-saw engagement continued throughout the night. Although armed, neither side opened fire, instead using batons or clubs and throwing or rolling down stones on each other's positions. Due to better connectivity on their side, the PLA were able to move troops forward in APCs, which changed the balance in their favour. Joshi rang me up at around 0130 hours on 16 June, informing me of the unfolding situation. He also said that he feared there were as yet an unspecified number of fatal casualties, including perhaps the CO himself. Even though the news was bad, I told Joshi (Jo) that we must hit back this time at least, and make them pay the price for their misadventure. Daylight revealed a not-so-favourable situation. Few jawans who could not make it back at night or who had

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